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Learning Space

NEWSPAPER

13th July, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

28th WEEK



DRUG CONTROL ... GLOBAL EXPERIENCE

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... Social Justice & Governance



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

13th JULY, 2018

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Smoke and errors

Punjab government's approach to drug menace is counter-productive. Compulsions of electoral politics and demagoguery continue to trump common sense, decency and evidence about what doesn't work.



ARJUNAV KUMAR

Q192. AGONY: A person who is in agony is in pain. But, in some circumstances, the word agony can also mean a state of intense suffering. In such cases, the word agony is used to describe a state of intense suffering that is caused by a physical or emotional pain. For example, a person who is in agony from a physical injury is in a state of intense suffering that is caused by the pain of the injury. Similarly, a person who is in agony from a emotional pain is in a state of intense suffering that is caused by the pain of the emotion. In both cases, the word agony is used to describe a state of intense suffering that is caused by a physical or emotional pain.

ward to a metropolitan outcry and action in the media, the government of Japan has announced a series of measures to curb drug use. These include cracking down on drug traffickers, providing counseling and after-care for people who use drugs, and more intensive nationwide monitoring and distribution by health clinics. Takiguchi saw from the top, some national authorities down to working level, and was aware of the sale of opiates without prescription. What he wanted to know was how to deal with the sale of drugs problem. The best figures available are based on survey analysis, but he remembers being alerted to this specific problem when one top and one at, at that, said yes.

[illegible]

But before Pappas looks at the costs, even we on drugs, it might be worthwhile to look at the methods adopted by insider campaigns elsewhere. Broadly speaking there are four distinct approaches. They differ from each other in emphasis being the role of courts, through legal or extra-legal means, and the role of campaigning and now, in tackling both the courts and the media officials.



Citation:

12,000 people have been eliminated in previous years since 2003. Is improving consumption and distribution in the Philippines not as important as providing education to young graduates and governments across the world. More importantly, is it not the responsibility of the Philippine Court to safeguard citizens' living rights in the ethics adopted by President Duterte. There are those who doubt any government's responsibility in doing this itself. Is it a source of uncertainty in extreme politics. One can only speculate that Duterte's administration is optimistic and uses cost-effective liberalized on-site activity. While addressing the society's major substructure in commerce, is it only hoped that the overall social change, that better world can be completed by government and the society and the political culture can be more democratic.

The second approach is America's health policies on HIV and AIDS. The implementation of the "drug czar" plan is reflected through several key policy decisions in policy implementation. The first decision is on the availability of drugs. The second decision is on the availability of information. The third decision is on the availability of services. The fourth decision is on the availability of support. The fifth decision is on the availability of research. The sixth decision is on the availability of education. The seventh decision is on the availability of prevention. The eighth decision is on the availability of treatment. The ninth decision is on the availability of care. The tenth decision is on the availability of support. The eleventh decision is on the availability of research. The twelfth decision is on the availability of education. The thirteenth decision is on the availability of prevention. The fourteenth decision is on the availability of treatment. 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The two other approaches to anti-drug policy are directly related. They emphasize de-contrabandization for recreational users and harm-reduction through treatment for addicts. They differ on the decontrabandization of distribution. One approach favors decriminalizing the entire distribution of street-level drugs

As SEP Haridwar's study these years, I handled the security for the festival with the largest animal consumption on an airplane, namely the Kanwar Mela. This is, of course, due to the fact that the most in 12 years Kanwar Mela that attracts devotees of Lord Shiva and being from all over the world. Try to study implementing the NDEP there, and you will have a full-scale one. Similarly, opium consumption has widespread acceptance, especially in Punjab and Rajasthan. And not all users are addicts who are causing irreparable harm to themselves and their families. Just as everyone who consumes alcohol in moderation is not a drunkard.

lation of consumption and distribution. The observed disparities and their results are yet to be fully understood. However, partly looking at the results from economic development in the Philippines and the U.S. these two approaches would appear to be complementary in the Indian context.

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the 1990s, the focus has been on the environmental consequences of urbanization and on the demographic factors that speed urbanization. The theory and the overwhelming evidence about such is clearly on one's side. Nonetheless, the title of public opinion is slowly turning against the policy-led, environment-and-urbanization-as-a-disaster-to-be-avoided strategy. The Global Commission on the Future of Cities, which includes such figures as John Auer, Paul Walker and Sir John Gledhill, came out with a report in 2010 warning against too much urbanization. The government's response to the report was to engage in more urban reform and to be based on the idea that the city is the best place for the development of a sustainable society.



*The Indian***EXPRESS**
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

12th July, 2018

1 Smoke and errors

Punjab government's approach to drug menace is counter-productive. Compulsions of electoral politics and demagoguery continue to trump common sense, decency and evidence about what doesn't work.

Once again, Punjab Police is facing the heat. Not from terrorists, but from the drug menace. The recent incidents of drug overdose-related deaths have brought the spotlight back on the drug menace in the state, and on the role of the Punjab Police in curbing it. Or, as many allege, its role in aiding and abetting the drug cartels. The drug-related deaths have coincided with tough action against police officials suspected of having direct links with the drug cartels. Prima facie, the sequence of events seems to confirm the worst fears of the public about the links between the drug cartels and the police. This perception may have some justification but, as with most perceptions, it draws attention from a more thoughtful and effective response to a problem.

Faced with a massive public outcry and criticism in the media, the government of Punjab has announced a series of measures to tackle the drug menace. These include mandatory drug tests for all government employees, proposing the death penalty for drug peddlers and a more intensive crackdown on drug consumption and distribution by Punjab Police. Taking their cue from the top, some overzealous authorities have gone a step forward and even banned the sale of syringes without a prescription. What is startling is that there is no reliable data about the scale of the drug problem. The best figures available are based on a very small survey. So, the measures being adopted are in response to a problem whose scope and size are, at best, a wild guess.

The reaction to these measures has been mixed. And it is, of course, premature to comment about their effectiveness. Or whether steps like mandatory testing would be administratively feasible, or legally tenable. What is beyond dispute is that the drug menace has been an intensely political and emotive issue in Punjab for the last five years or so.

1 Smoke and errors

It was a key issue in the assembly elections of 2017. It is an issue that has found expression in films like *Udta Punjab*, a title which has entered popular lingo, as well as countless songs that form the core of Punjabi pop culture. This acknowledgement and celebration of drug consumption in Punjab's popular culture is completely at variance with the overt religiosity of Sikhs and the key tenets of the religion. Despite this dichotomy, the tragic loss of lives due to a drug overdose, and the visible emotional trauma and financial stress caused to drug addicts and their families, mean that it is entirely understandable that no political party can afford to be seen as being soft on drugs. Not just in Punjab, but anywhere in the country. This is also the situation in most societies around the world.

But before Punjab embarks on its own war on drugs, it might be worthwhile to look at the methods adopted by similar campaigns elsewhere. Broadly speaking, there are four distinct approaches. They differ from each other in emphasising the role of coercion, through legal or extra-legal means, and the role of counselling and care, in tackling both the consumers and suppliers of drugs.

At one extreme is the approach of the Philippines, where the government of President Rodrigo Duterte has given carte blanche to the law enforcement agencies. As a result, by some estimates, as many as 12,000 people have been eliminated in police encounters since 2016. Its impact on drug consumption and distribution in the Philippines is not known. But it has provoked protests within the country and more strident condemnation from agencies and governments around the world. More seriously, in February 2018, the International Criminal Court in the Hague announced an inquiry into the tactics adopted by President Duterte. Even an otherwise enthusiastic proponent of no-nonsense policing like myself feels a sense of unease at such extreme tactics. One can only imagine the long-term impact of such indiscriminate and unaccountable brutalisation on a society. While a section of our society too might advocate such measures, I can only hope that they are a lunatic fringe.

...Contd.



1 Smoke and errors

Such tactics would also be completely against the constitutional values and the political culture of our democracy. The second approach is America's much publicised War on Drugs. This emphasises the role of punishment of both drug users and peddlers. It is accompanied by generous military aid and robust military interventions in drug producing countries. The War on Drugs began in the time of President Richard Nixon and was given a fresh impetus during the tenure of presidents George Bush Sr and Bill Clinton. By some estimates, it costs the US some \$50 billion a year. For that kind of money, its results have been underwhelming. The street price of most popular drugs in cities like New York has remained roughly constant in inflation-adjusted terms indicating that the availability of drugs has not really been affected. However, if the aim of the policy was to lock up anyone associated with drug consumption and distribution, it has been a grand success. The US today incarcerates a greater proportion of its citizens than any other democracy. And a large proportion of these is for non-violent drug offences. In the Indian context, given our clogged criminal courts and overcrowded prisons, it is difficult to see how this approach can be adopted.

The two other approaches to anti-drug policy are closely related. They emphasise decriminalisation for recreational users and harm reduction through treatment for addicts. They differ on the decriminalisation of distribution. One approach favours complete decriminalisation and strict regulation of drug supplies, while the other is more ambivalent about it. Decriminalisation of users only has been adopted by certain states in the US whereas countries like Canada, Portugal and Holland are experimenting with decriminalisation of consumption and distribution. These are novel experiments and their results are yet to be fully understood. However, purely looking at the results from more muscular approaches like the Philippines and the US, these two approaches would appear to be more relevant in the Indian context.

1 Smoke and errors

Apart from legal and economic constraints of adopting a US-style War on Drugs, there is also the issue of cultural attitudes with regard to consumption of specific substances like marijuana and opium. In large parts of the country, the consumption of these two substances has great social acceptability. As SSP Haridwar for nearly three years, I handled the security for the festival with the largest annual consumption of marijuana, namely the Kanwar Mela. This is, of course, dwarfed by the once in 12 years Kumbh Mela that attracts devotees of Lord Shiva and bhang from all over the world. Try strictly implementing the NDPS there, and you will have a full-scale riot. Similarly, opium consumption has widespread acceptability, especially in Punjab and Rajasthan. And not all users are addicts who are causing irreversible harm to themselves and their families. Just as everyone who consumes alcohol is not an alcoholic, anyone who consumes these substances should not be treated as an addict, or worse, a criminal. The failure of our drug policies to make a reasonable distinction between a recreational user and an addict is the collective failure of our moral imagination. A greater failure is the tendency to treat compulsive addicts as despicable criminals, and not as fellow human beings in need of care and counselling.

For far too long, on the issue of drugs, the compulsions of electoral politics and sheer demagoguery have trumped common sense, decency and the overwhelming evidence about what clearly doesn't work. Worldwide, the tide of public opinion is slowly turning against the police-led, enforcement and punishment-based approach to drug control. The Global Commission on Drug Policy that included notable figures like Kofi Annan, Paul Volcker and the late Asma Jahangir came out with a report in 2011 advocating complete decriminalisation. The government and people of Punjab must engage in serious reflection and debate based on accurate data about the scale and nature of the drug menace on this vital issue, before adopting a cure that may turn out to be much worse than the disease.

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Smoke and errors

Punjab government's approach to drug menace is counter-productive. Compulsions of electoral politics and demagoguery continue to trump common sense, decency and evidence about what doesn't work



ARVIND KUMAR

ONCE KARNI PUNJABI was a leading figure in the Punjabi community, but from the drug menace, he has been driven away. He is now a public figure in the drug world. From his, the impact of the drug menace on the Punjabi community is evident. He is now a public figure in the drug world. From his, the impact of the drug menace on the Punjabi community is evident.



Illustration

1.5 lakh people have been arrested in Punjab since 2015 for drug offences. The government's approach to drug menace is counter-productive. Compulsions of electoral politics and demagoguery continue to trump common sense, decency and evidence about what doesn't work.

The second approach is America's 'tough on drugs' policy. This approach is also counter-productive. Compulsions of electoral politics and demagoguery continue to trump common sense, decency and evidence about what doesn't work.

As NIP has been for nearly three years, I handled the security for the festival with the largest annual gathering of Punjabis, namely the Karam Mahe. This is, of course, a very big gathering. I handled the security for the festival with the largest annual gathering of Punjabis, namely the Karam Mahe.

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UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... Social Justice & Governance

Government policies and interventions for development in various sectors and issues arising out of their design and implementation.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Decriminalisation for recreational users and harm reduction through treatment for addicts appears to be a viable solution for drug menace in India. Examine the issue, enumerating different methodologies followed in various Countries.



The Indian EXPRESS
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

12th July, 2018



DIFFERENT APPROACHES ADOPTED FOR CONTROLLING DRUGS ACROSS THE WORLD

APPROACH NO. 1



Such tactics would be completely against the constitutional values and the political culture of our democracy.

- 1 Philippines is the case in point, the President Rodrigo Duterte has given free hand to the law enforcement agencies, as a result 12,000 have been eliminated in police encounters since 2016.
- 2 It led to strident condemnation from agencies and Governments around the world.
- 3 In February 2018, the International Criminal Court in The Hague announced an inquiry into the tactics adopted by President Duterte.

DIFFERENT APPROACHES ADOPTED FOR CONTROLLING DRUGS ACROSS THE WORLD

APPROACH NO. 2



In spite of all these things, the availability of drugs has not really been affected. The US today incarcerates a greater proportion of its citizens than any other democracy. A large proportion of these is for non-violent drug offences. In the Indian context, given our clogged criminal courts and overcrowded prisons, it is difficult to follow this approach.

- 1 It is about USA's much publicized War on Drugs
- 2 This emphasises the punishment of both drug users and peddlers.
- 3 It is accompanied by generous military aid and robust military interventions in drug producing countries. It costs the US some \$ 50 billion a year.
- 4 The War on Drugs began at the time of President Richard Nixon and got fresh impetus during the tenures of Presidents George Bush Sr and Bill Clinton.

DIFFERENT APPROACHES ADOPTED FOR CONTROLLING DRUGS ACROSS THE WORLD

APPROACH NO. 3 & 4



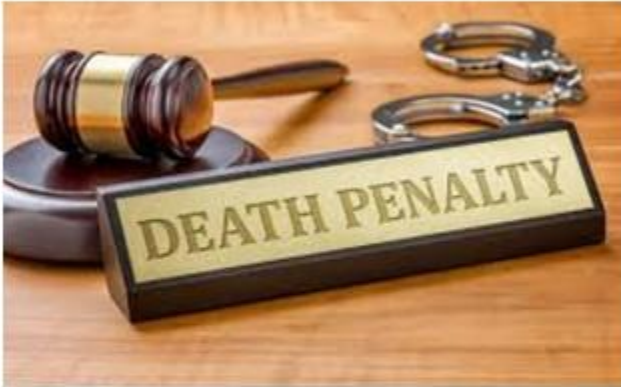
These two approaches would appear to be more relevant in the Indian context.

- 1** Decriminalisation for recreational users and harm reduction through treatment for addicts.
- 2** Both these approaches differ on the decriminalisation of distribution.
- 3** One approach favours complete decriminalisation and strict regulation of drug supplies, and the other is more ambivalent about it.
- 4** Decriminalisation of users only has been adopted by certain States in the US and countries like Canada, Portugal and Holland are experimenting with decriminalisation of consumption and distribution. These are novel experiments.

CULTURAL ASPECTS IN INDIA



- 1 In several parts of the Country, consumption of substances like marijuana and opium has great social acceptability.
- 2 There is consumption of marijuana at the festival Kanwar Yatra in Uttarakhand, similarly Kumbh Mela also has got lot of consumption
- 3 Opium consumption has wide spread acceptability in Punjab and Rajasthan, not all the users are addicts
- 4 Our drug policies should make a reasonable distinction between a recreational user and an addict.
- 5 Moreover, the greater failure is the tendency to treat compulsive addicts as criminals and not as fellow human beings in need of care and counselling.



Worldwide, the tide of public opinion is slowly turning against the policed, enforcement and punishment-based approach. The Global Commission on Drug Policy included notable figures like Kofi Annan and the late Asma Jahangir and they came out with a report in 2011 advocating complete decriminalisation.

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